



MONTHLY UPDATE

DR Congo: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-29 · 61 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

An interministerial order pricing digital-sector duties, taxes and fees took effect on signature on 20 July 2026 and was suspended by government communiqué on 3 August.

Two strategic documents reached validation without adoption: the national AI strategy on 27 July, subject to amendments, and the sectoral digital economy policy 2026-2030 on 22 July, subject to completing its costing and indicators. The backbone's own numbers reached the Council of Ministers on 3 August: 7,000 km deployed against more than 18,500 km.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Experts validated the sectoral digital economy policy 2026-2030 on 21 and 22 July, subject to completing the costing, indicators and institutional responsibilities. A restitution workshop on 29 and 30 July presented a ten-dimension maturity diagnostic and named the instruments to be articulated: the digital and data strategies, the AI strategy, the identity platform, the sovereign cloud, a certification authority and a cybersecurity agency, plus a rule barring AI platform deployment without data quality, auditability and human supervision.

The connectivity side of that framework acquired numbers in August. The universal service fund published a National Connectivity Strategy 2026-2035 built on a shared-infrastructure model led by a tower company, and signed subsidy agreements with the four mobile operators to extend service to 40 underserved localities covering about 258,000 people, against a target of 3,000 localities and 16 million people by 2030. The strategy text is not held, and neither the subsidy amounts, the tower company nor the selection rule for the first 40 localities is stated.

Legislation and regulation

The interministerial order on digital-sector duties, taxes and fees was in force on signature on 20 July under its article 5. It sets a two-tier dollar schedule keyed to whether a provider is judged dominant, running from US\$2,500 to US\$15,000 for cloud services and US\$25,000 to US\$100,000 for data-centre declaration, with one startup line at US\$100. It was suspended by government communiqué on 3 August. Neither the gazetted order nor the suspending communiqué is held.

Two regulators agreed on 22 July to form joint inspection teams and enforce local-content subcontracting rules on large operators, scoped beyond telecoms to digital services and e-commerce; no written protocol is held.

The digital code is being applied to speech. On 15 August the justice minister [restated the government's determination to clean up Congolese cyberspace and said prosecutions were already under way for public insults and defamation on social platforms under the Code du numérique](#), after receiving an NGO memorandum on 13 August. No case number, charge or judgment is held.

A new schedule of [taxes, permits and sanctions now governs the digital sphere](#). The base holds a legal analysis of it rather than the instrument, so the issuing authority, the instrument number and the entry-into-force date are not established here.

Data protection

Data protection has an authority that does not exist and a population whose service does not reach it. The [national data protection authority is still not created](#), named again in July as a link in the cybersecurity chain after the minister said in March that structuring a professional network precedes it — two years of the same finding, running alongside a twenty-year exclusive foreign concession over citizens' identity data. In the east, [Baraka and Fizi have had telecoms and internet cut for months amid operations near Epupu, and humanitarian organisations' satellite kits were seized on the Baraka mayor's order](#), closing the last backup channel. It is reported as war damage and fuel-access failure rather than an ordered restriction, and no licensing or administrative decision for occupied territory is held.

Regional collaboration

The [African Telecommunications Union's return to Kinshasa was ratified on 23 July at the union's plenipotentiary conference in Abuja, after the country paid more than US\\$1.4m in arrears](#). No date for the move is stated, the arrears figure and the account are the minister's own, and a bid for a seat on the ITU's administrative council for 2027 to 2030 is still pending.

Standards

The telecommunications regulator set on 22 July a [binding escalation path for consumer complaints: the operator first, up to 30 working days, then referral to the regulator](#).

The telecoms regulator [installed equipment giving it near-real-time access to mobile operators' own data](#) on service quality, traffic flows and spectrum, which the ministry says will let it establish breaches objectively rather than on operators' own reporting. No first enforcement action or published measurement has followed.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A [standing consultation mechanism between the ministry and the sector network was agreed at a working session on 6 August](#), after the dispute over the digital-sector tariff. No constituting text, membership or meeting schedule is stated, and the agreement is known from a communiqué carried by the state news agency.

The audiovisual and communications council and the press-freedom council [formalised an institutional partnership by memorandum](#) after two days of work on 19 and 20 August 2026. No work programme, joint power or first action under it is on file.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The month's one signed arrangement puts a commercial bank inside the digital ministry's programme. The digital economy ministry and a commercial bank [signed a memorandum on 13 August to modernise the financial sector and accelerate banking inclusion](#), covering digital identity and artificial-intelligence integration under the 2019 national digital plan and the 2023 Digital Code. No term, value, workplan or data-protection provision is published — for an arrangement that names digital identity as in scope.

New investments

A development fund committed [US\\$32.8m into an upsized US\\$179m senior secured facility on 5 August](#), funding 728 new passive towers to take the network to 1,800, 70% of them rural, with solar and battery upgrades. [The same lender committed US\\$30m to the same borrower in 2023, when the network stood at 1,072 active towers.](#)

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Deployment of the transformation project's fibre backbone was reported to the Council on 3 August: [7,000 km laid against more than 18,500 km, leaving 11,500 km outstanding](#) and tied to connecting 145 territories by 2030. The minister attributed the pace to budget constraints and a low disbursement rate on external financing, blamed on donor procedure.

Coverage arrived from orbit before it arrived by fibre. An operator [commercially launched a satellite-to-mobile service on 14 August, the first African operator to take the technology out of testing](#): a compatible LTE Android handset with a clear view of the sky reaches messaging and SMS through satellites where there is no terrestrial network, with no dish, router or other equipment, and the [regulator has confirmed a phased rollout](#). The service is stated as designed for light data, and the only access term published is a [free 30-day trial for customers who register through the operator's app](#); no standing tariff, coverage map or subscriber figure is on the record.

Starlink users in Kinshasa [face four to six months of possible slowdowns while the network is congested](#). No subscriber count, capacity figure or remediation date accompanies the notice.

Data Storage

On 29 July the digital economy minister named a [sovereign government cloud among the ministry's projects to be ordered and made executable](#), alongside the digital and data strategies, the identity platform and a certification authority. No hosting location, operator, procurement or budget line was stated.

A data-centre group lifted [committed capital from US\\$350m to US\\$380m](#) across six markets, none of it allocated to DR Congo in the source.

Cybersecurity

A workshop named a [national cybersecurity agency as one of five bodies whose roles in the incident-notification chain must be clarified, explicitly without creating new institutions](#); no creating instrument, budget line or head is held.

An operator launched a [subscriber-level child filtering service on 17 July](#) from 50 units for 30 days — a commercial service, not a state measure, with no subscriber figure.

DPI

Data Exchange

On 29 July a [national electronic certification authority](#) was named, not established; the July order already prices [qualified trust services](#) at US\$30,000 foreign and US\$10,000 local.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A sector chief in Walikale told the provincial interior division on 23 July that his civil-status office had [no birth registers for several months and had stopped registering newborns](#); the province promised resupply with no date, and the stated consequences are exclusion from school enrolment and from proof of nationality.

Digital Payments and Fintech

A card-network executive confirmed on 2 July a [live use case settling mobile-wallet top-ups in stablecoins in the background](#), bypassing correspondent banking. On 14 July a card network and a domestic payments company announced [prepaid card issuance](#), the domestic partner serving more than three million customers through 4,000 agents.

Registries

Business formalisation was inspected on 28 July: the portal proposes a legal form and tracks a file in real time and the application [issues sole-trader attestations in under 48 hours, while full online company creation is not possible](#).

Two further registers were announced as part of a financial-sector package rather than as builds. A [modernised credit-risk registry and an electronic movable-collateral registry are to be built with the central bank, alongside a new deposit-guarantee fund](#), in a World Bank programme to expand financing for small and medium firms that also carries a rollout of 10,000 point-of-sale terminals and agent networks. No instrument, custodian, timetable or access rule is stated for either registry, and no data-protection provision is reported for the credit file.

The registry ground also drew a vendor. A Kenyan platform operator [pitched the digital economy ministry on 12 August on digital company registries, beneficial-ownership traceability and real-time state-revenue tracking](#), citing its own deployments in Malawi and South Sudan; the minister asked officials to continue talks toward a partnership. It is a sales meeting, and the claims in it are the vendor's.

The company that built the vehicle identification platform [is refusing to hand it to the government without compensation](#) and is preparing legal action in Belgium after a mediation attempt failed. A state registry whose operating platform the state does not control is a governance exposure and not only a commercial dispute; no contract terms, valuation or filing date is on file.

Sectoral management information systems

A seminar opened on 15 July on a [public-enterprise digitalisation plan for 2026-2028](#) covering transaction traceability, automated validation circuits and data reconciliation, with no system, budget line or deployment date named.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The month's only movement in government platforms was a procurement, and not the state's own: Belgium's development agency [opened a tender on 1 August for artificial-intelligence modules to be built into the national employment agency's platform](#), for job matching aimed at youth unemployment, with offers due on 7 September. No contract value, award or delivery date is on record, and the digital government platform it would sit beside remains at Planned with its target already missed.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Kinshasa urban administration agents demonstrated on 23 July over [two months of unpaid salary, with beneficiary listings already transmitted to the paying bank](#) and neither bank staff nor payroll agents attending the appointed payment.

Technology

AI

A stakeholder workshop of 23 to 27 July in Kinshasa [validated the draft national artificial intelligence strategy subject to amendments](#), on four pillars aligned to the national development plan on a 2030 horizon. No adoption date was established and the text is not held. The same sessions recorded that bodies already acting across digital, research, data, cybersecurity and regulation have [roles not yet sufficiently articulated in a common steering architecture](#).

ICT Industry

Two regulators [agreed at a first working session to coordinate enforcement of local-content subcontracting, with scope stated beyond telecoms to electronic communications, digital services and electronic commerce](#). It is a meeting outcome rather than a text: no signed instrument, no inspection conducted and no reporting obligation established, and nothing records an enforcement action since.

Innovation ecosystem

A government communiqué of 3 August confirmed that the [Startup Act implementing texts remain in preparation](#): four draft decrees adopted in May 2025 to operationalise the fiscal, customs and exchange advantages of the 2022 ordinance-law, none in force fifteen months on. None of the four texts is held.

Capacity

Literacy

A [campaign to publicise the digital code launched in Kinshasa on 6 August, mobilising 2,000 young volunteers for 30 days at two publications a day](#) on cybersecurity, data protection and responsible internet use, carried by the ministry with UNDP support. The code was promulgated in March 2023, and no budget for the campaign and no measure of its effect is stated.

Training and skills

The employment office launched a [portal and mobile application in July](#) on which jobseekers register skills and employers post needs, intended to build a national skills database. It was externally financed, and no user or placement figure is held.

The digital economy ministry [opened the first of a planned series of five-day training sessions for 580 of its own agents and managers](#) at the INPES in Kinshasa on 24 August 2026. No curriculum, completion target or budget line is published.

The land ministry [closed a roughly month-long course for 50 conservators of property titles on 25 August](#), drawn from several provinces and run with the national school of administration as part of a capacity-building programme under the land reform, setting it alongside archiving operations already running in seven pilot land districts of Kinshasa; no further wave or provincial timetable is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

On 23 July a state bank and the payroll monitoring committee settled the technical and organisational terms for [paying civil servants in rural territories, scoped to three named territories and others where no other bank operates](#). August 2026 was named as a target, with the bank's director-general calling a fixed date premature and the state contract unsigned. What subscribers pay moved the other way. Users and resellers in Bukavu say a [1GB bundle that ran 48 hours at 1,500 Congolese francs now expires in 24 at the same price](#), and a 2GB 48-hour bundle at 2,000 francs has been replaced by 1GB over 72 hours; subscribers across the eastern provinces [report the same pattern across four operators and have asked a consumer body to intervene](#). Both ends are subscribers' accounts; no operator or regulator has stated anything.

Digital divides

This is the month's clearest movement with both ends dated. The universal service fund [signed subsidy conventions with four operators on 8 August for a first tranche of 40 localities, about 258,000 people](#), against a national diagnostic published the day before finding nearly 3,000 uncovered localities — about 4.3m people — and coverage of 77% 2G, 68% 3G and 57% 4G. A [second phase of 300 sites is planned, with a 2030 target of 3,000 localities and 100 digital community centres](#). An unfunded fund at the window's start, a first funded tranche at its end; no per-locality budget or fund appropriation figure is held. The diagnostic's own spread is wide: [coverage runs from about 98% in Kinshasa to 14% in Tshuapa and 28% in each of Kwango and Sud-Ubangi](#), and the fund is [drafting a national strategy that prioritises investment by coverage gap, population, economic activity, public infrastructure and geography, naming the Lobito, National and Peace corridors as its three strategic routes and shared passive infrastructure as its approach](#). No adoption date, budget or target is published for it.

Data

National statistics

The planning minister [announced recruitment of mapping agents and fixed general enumeration for July 2027](#), which would be the country's first census since 1984. No budget line, financing source, implementing contract or cartography completion figure is held. Separately a [digital sector barometer was announced after a working session on 6 August](#) to give government figures on firms' activity, turnover, growth and job creation — proposed by the industry body rather than imposed by the state, with no operator, methodology or first-issue date stated.

Open data

The month's one open-data movement came from the central bank rather than from the state's open-data policy, which the base still does not hold. The bank [relaunched its website on 14 August as a public economic-data portal carrying exchange rates, inflation, interest rates, statistics and indicators, with a currency converter and a search facility](#), its governor framing the site as part of a reform whose stated objectives include digitalising payments and automating control processes. It is a publication channel rather than a data release: no machine-readable download, licence or update schedule is stated, and the national data governance strategy remains **Not held**.

Geopolitics

China activities

On 3 July a memorandum was signed with a Chinese supplier for a 2,100 km route – 1,700 km along the Congo River plus nearly 400 km terrestrial – at a stated US\$1.5bn, with more than US\$400m required for the first phase. Both figures are company-reported, and there is no financing close, contract or works.

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